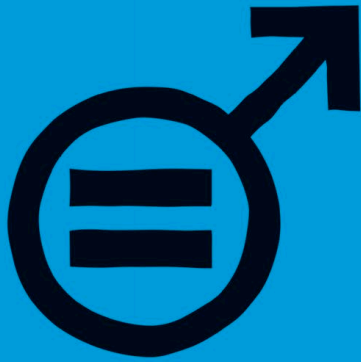




MEN ARE BORN AND REMAIN FREE AND EQUAL IN RIGHTS

THE DECLARATION OF THE RIGHTS OF MAN (1789)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Human rights

BEFORE

c. 1750 BCE In Mesopotamia, the Code of Hammurabi lists basic rights and punishments.

539 BCE Cyrus the Great decrees religious tolerance for his conquered subjects in Babylon.

1215 England's Magna Carta is signed by King John.

1776 The Virginia Declaration of Rights influences the US Declaration of Independence.

AFTER

1948 In the wake of the atrocities of World War II, the United Nations' Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) defines rights worldwide.

1950 The European Convention on Human Rights (ECHR) draws on the UDHR, enforcing individual rights across Europe.

The Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen was a landmark statement of human rights. It emerged at the start of the French Revolution and laid down the principle that by law all men are equal, with equal rights to liberty, private property, safety, and freedom from oppression. This idea has shaped the modern world.

The events that gave rise to the Declaration started in May 1789, when King Louis XVI was compelled by financial crisis and widespread agitation to reconvene the Estates General, the legislative assembly, after a gap of 175 years. The Estates General comprised three groups, or estates—the clergy, the nobility, and the people—and Louis insisted that each group had a single vote. This meant that the two elite estates, the clergy and the nobility, would always outvote the people.

The National Assembly

On June 17, 1789, the enraged “Third Estate,” the people, declared a separate National Assembly to make laws themselves. Locked out of the official assembly hall, they convened on the Royal Tennis Court instead. Here, they resolved to set out the principles by which France

would be governed. A fundamental principle was that, for “the good of all,” the Assembly would govern only with the consent of the people.

For this reason, it was necessary to define the rights of every citizen, and so the Declaration was drafted initially by the Marquis de Lafayette, in consultation with American

All men are equal and **no man has a right to rule over any other.**



But men may choose to **give the power to rule** to the monarch and the government.



So the monarch and the government **rule on behalf of the nation** and only **by the consent of the people.**